

MODAL VERBS

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We New Yorkers live in a city that is on a gradual transition toward environmental sustainability, but we are a long way from the place we need to end up. A circular economy where there is no waste and where all material outputs become inputs is well beyond our technological and organizational capacity today. But that does not mean we **shouldn't** think about how to get from here to there. Much of the work in building environmental sustainability requires the development of systems that enable us to live our lives as we wish while damaging the planet as little as possible. Large-scale institutions are needed to manage sewage treatment and drinking water, to develop renewable energy and build a modern energy grid. Government policy is needed to ensure the conservation of forests, oceans, and biodiversity. Pandemic avoidance requires global, national and local systems of public health. Climate change mitigation and adaptation also require collective action. What then can individuals do?

Many times, you **will** judge that the financial and environmental cost of the trip is far outweighed by the benefits. Those are the times you **should** travel. My argument here is that it is the thought process, the analysis of environmental costs and benefits, that is at the heart of an individual's responsibility for environmental sustainability. Individuals are responsible for thinking about their impact on the environment and, when possible, minimize the damage they do to the planet.

Everyone needs to turn on the lights at night, start the shower in the morning, turn on the air conditioning and possibly drive somewhere on Mother's Day. I would never argue that you **should** give up these forms of consumption. Instead, I believe we **should** all pay attention to the resources we use and the impact it has. We are responsible for that thought process and the related analysis of how we, as individuals, **might** accomplish the same ends with less environmentally damaging means.

Modal Verbs are special auxiliary verbs that express modality - ability, possibility, permission, obligation and etc. Unlike regular verbs, modals don't change form with different subjects. They are essential in adding further context to sentences and help in conveying the modalities that have been mentioned above, among others.

Modal verbs are generally used to express the following modalities

- Probability/Certainty
- Obligation, Necessity, and Prohibition
- Ability and Permission
- Advice, Criticism, and Regret
- Hypothetical Situations and Conditional Results
- Formal and Official Functions

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Strong certainty (positive)	must	must have + past participle	• She must be the director of the company. • He must have been informed about the changes.
Strong certainty (negative)	can't/cannot	can't/cannot have + past participle	• They can't be serious about the proposal. • The team can't have completed the project so quickly.
Strong probability	will	will have + past participle	• They will arrive by 5 pm. • They will have reached a decision by now.
Medium probability	should ought to	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• The package should arrive tomorrow. • The package should have arrived yesterday. • The documents ought to have been signed last week.
Medium possibility	may could	may have + past participle could have + past participle	• The CEO may approve the budget. • The board may have discussed this already. • This solution could work. • They could have won with better preparation.
Slight possibility	might	might have + past participle	• She might join us later. • They might have overlooked this detail.

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Strong obligation	must have to need to	had to have + past participle needed to have + past participle	• You must submit the report by Friday. • The contract had to have been finalized before the merger. • We needed to have secured those permits earlier.
Medium obligation	should ought to	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• You should attend the conference. • You should have informed me earlier. • Companies ought to have invested in cybersecurity.
Absence of obligation	don't have to don't need to needn't	didn't have to + infinitive didn't need to + infinitive needn't have + past participle	• You don't have to finish this today. • You didn't have to work overtime. • You needn't have spent so much money.
Prohibition	must not cannot	must not have + past participle cannot have + past participle	• Employees must not share confidential information. • They must not have followed protocol. • Visitors cannot enter this area. • They cannot have authorized this expenditure.

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Ability	can be able to	could was/were able to could have + past participle	• She can speak five languages. • He could swim by age four. • They were able to solve the problem. • We could have implemented a better solution.
Permission	can may could might	could have + past participle might have + past participle	• You can use my office while I'm away. • May I ask a question? • Could I see the report? • You could have borrowed my laptop. • They might have allowed it under different circumstances.
Request	can could would will	could have + past participle would have + past participle	• Can you help me with this? • Could you send the documents? • Would you mind reviewing this? • Could you have notified us sooner? • Would you have preferred a different approach?

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Advice	should ought to had better	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• You should review the contract carefully. • We ought to consider all options. • You'd better leave now. • The team should have consulted experts. • They ought to have tested the system more thoroughly.
Criticism	should ought to	should have + past participle ought to have + past participle	• The management should address these concerns. • They should have anticipated these problems. • The company ought to have disclosed this information.
Regret	--	should have + past participle could have + past participle would have + past participle	• I should have studied harder. • We could have won the contract. • They would have attended if they had known.

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Hypothetical present	would could might	--	• This approach would solve our problems. • The investment could yield significant returns. • The technology might change the industry.
Hypothetical past	--	would have + past participle could have + past participle might have + past participle	• The project would have succeeded with better planning. • We could have avoided these issues. • Their strategy might have worked in a different market.
Unreal conditional	would could might	would have + past participle could have + past participle might have + past participle	• If prices fell, demand would increase. • If they had invested earlier, they would have made a profit. • If resources were available, we could complete this sooner. • If we had known, we could have prepared better.

Function	Present/Future	Past (Modal Perfect)	Example Sentences
Formal suggestion	shall	shall have + past participle	• Shall we proceed with the meeting? • The parties shall have concluded negotiations by the specified date.
Formal obligation	shall	shall have + past participle	• The applicant shall provide all required documentation. • The contractor shall have completed all work by June 30th.
Formal request/offer	would might	would have + past participle might have + past participle	• Would you be willing to reconsider? • Might I suggest an alternative? • Would you have preferred a different arrangement? • Might I have been misinformed about the situation?

RECAP

- Modal verbs modify main verbs to express attitudes about actions
 - They convey degrees of certainty, obligation, possibility, and permission
- Different modals carry distinct levels of formality and intensity
- Present forms (must, will, can) focus on current/future situations
- Perfect forms (must have, would have) relate to past situations
- Context determines appropriate modal selection
- Mastering modals enhances precision in communication
- Common uses include making requests, giving advice, expressing regrets, and describing hypothetical scenarios

THANK you

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